

Democrats' Senate leads are stable

送信者: EG US Daily 受信日時: 2026-10-03 00:37

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The most worrying sign for Republicans is not only that Democrats’ margin keeps increasing, but that Republicans’ share is now falling. It has spent almost all of 2026 hovering around 42%; since late September, though, it has fallen to around 41%, as Democrats have increased their share from around 48% to 50%. This appears to be a story not just of Democrats growing in strength in the final days of the campaign, but of Republicans weakening.

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In Senate races, this week hasn’t seen much movement—but with Democrats maintaining small leads in enough races to flip the chamber, Republicans are running short on time to flip the dynamics back in their direction. Looking only at recent polls without a partisan sponsor, Democrats are on track for a majority (see table below), with Alaska the decisive race.

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Potential polling bias is, as always, a word of caution on seeing Democrats as too strong of favorites, and it’s worth remembering that, though Democrats’ leads in the key races have been durable, they’re not large in absolute terms. If the Senate polls are off by as much as they were in 2024, when they understated the Republican margin, Democrats will fall just short of a majority.

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Pollster bias in 2018 and 2022, the last two midterm cycles, was nearly zero; if polls can replicate that performance, Democrats would have 53 seats. While predicting the direction of bias ex ante is an exercise in futility, the fact that Democrats' leads are not robust to no-larger-than-usual polling biases—especially if polls understate Republican support among working-class white voters—is a key factor keeping our odds for Democrats flipping the Senate (55%) less bullish than some of the major forecasters.

Democrats' blue-state weakness is probably an incumbency effect. Even as Democrats keep gaining in the generic congressional ballot, a curious fact of this midterm cycle has been Democratic polling weakness in what should be solid Democratic states.

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This is playing out in a number of gubernatorial races: In deep-blue Oregon, the Democrat trails; in Wisconsin, the Democrat has a bare lead; in New York, Kathy Hochul isn't out-polling Democrats' 2024 margin of victory. It's present in Senate races too, especially Minnesota, where the Democrat leads by under two points—less than the margin by which Democrats won the state in 2024.

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While these numbers are indeed a word of caution on what looks like a larger blue wave by the week, it's also possible to reconcile them with evidence of a strongly Democratic-leaning national environment, on two grounds:

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National swing are rarely uniform. Analyses based on the national environment implicitly assume that voters' swing from 2024 will play out evenly across the country. That's a reasonable ex ante assumption, but it's worth noting that it rarely plays out like that in practice; instead, some areas swing by more, and some by less. In 2022, a good year for Republicans, Upper Midwest states moved toward Democrats, while New York and Florida moved far more to the right than the nationwide average. It wouldn't be surprising this year to see a smaller move to the left—or even no move at all—in some states.

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Anti-incumbent sentiment cuts both ways. An environment in which voters rate inflation and affordability as a top issue is an incumbent killer, as we've flagged since 2022. That tends to hurt Republicans, who are the national incumbent. But the overlapping nature of state and federal governments means that voters may not perceive Republicans as the exclusive incumbent in their state; in Oregon, Minnesota, and Wisconsin, Democrats are the state incumbent, and the sense that state governments have failed to abate cost-of-living concerns could be eating into their margins.

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Ultimately, we think the blue wave isn't a mirage, despite these less-than-stellar numbers for Democrats in some states. The evidence elsewhere—both from the generic ballot and from state-specific Senate and gubernatorial polling—is too overwhelming.

European diesel release may be last off-ramp to avoid US export curb. The US has asked European countries to release diesel from emergency stocks or face US diesel export restrictions. Such a release will likely be necessary to avoid US export curbs if US diesel prices reverse their recent declines by the middle of next week.

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The US is asking Europe to release 120 million barrels over 180 days, or 670,000 barrels per day, roughly matching the 500,000-600,000 bpd we expect from fully imposed restrictions (see: What to watch on diesel export restriction odds , 30 September 2026). This adds to about a third of EU stocks.

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French President Emmanuel Macron has indicated the G7 will release diesel fuel and crude oil from stockpiles. Even a release below the requested 120 million barrels will likely mollify Trump and push him further from export restrictions.

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Global diesel supply will stay tight into early winter; Russian and Chinese export bans, coupled with reduced Gulf supply, have taken about 1.6 million bpd of diesel export (~6% of global demand) off the market. The requested EU release would offset only about 40% of the shortfall; a full US export ban would nearly double it, though we expect any US restriction to affect about 500,000 bpd.

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Midterm politics will keep export curbs in play if diesel prices stay near records. For more, see European diesel release may be last offramp to avoid US export curb , 1 October 2026.

White House AI accord leaves labs exposed to regulators. US AI labs committed to four AI safety control layers—monitoring, internal verification, external audit, and oversight—in the White House Accord on Super Intelligence. Most of these were already in place, though, and none would delay or stop a model release.

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The accord dodged the antitrust problem rather than solving it. While the signatories agreed to meet regularly to establish best practices for AI safety, the White House remains opposed to a coordinated slowdown in development and an antitrust waiver that would enable one remains unlikely.

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Liability is the only outcome-based clause, as the agreement commits companies to ensure their models “do not hack or access technical systems in unintended ways.” This public promise gives state enforcers and plaintiffs a written benchmark for potential incidents, and may provide the basis for future federal regulation.

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After the signing of the accord the FTC widened an investigation into Anthropic, Open AI, and potentially other AI companies focused on incidents where models compromised outside systems. The probe existed before the accord, but the FTC could treat its violation as evidence of deceptive practices, and Chairman Andrew Ferguson has said labs can be held liable for what their models do.

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For more, see White House AI accord leaves labs exposed to regulators , 1 October 2026.

Quote of the Day

"Please, no." - Adam Hamilton, Democratic challenger to incumbent Senator Roger Marshall (R-KS), when asked if he'd want Kamala Harris to make a campaign appearance. Hamilton's comments fall in line with a growing view among candidates that support from the national-level party is politically unhelpful in competitive races, especially in the Midwest, and that candidates like Hamilton—formerly a Republican—or Josh Turek in Iowa are best off running their own races, letting them define their own political identity independent from that of the national party.

On the Radar

12-18 October: IMF and World Bank Annual Meetings

30-31 October: G20 Foreign Ministers' meeting

3 November: National midterm elections

9 November: Congress returns from recess

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

10 January: US-China tariff truce expires

Clayton Allen

Practice Head, United States

+1 202.903.0027

allen@eurasiagroup.net

Noah Daponte-Smith

Senior Analyst, United States

daponte-smith@eurasiagroup.net

Kendal Walker

Senior Analyst, United States

walker@eurasiagroup.net

Jason Walter

Researcher, United States

walter@eurasiagroup.net

Heather West

Practice Head, Geo-technology

west@eurasiagroup.net

EG US Daily

unitedstates@eurasiagroup.net

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